orders from the CBI. After repeated tries, Sri Kumar suggested that Kaarthikeyan take up the matter with New Delhi.

Kaarthikeyan went to Delhi and pressed the government for procuring more sophisticated VHF (very high frequency) and UHF direction finders to be able to compete with the highly sophisticated communication facility of the LTTE. The system available to the Indian intelligence agencies was outmoded. Getting caught up in bureaucratic tangles would not expedite the investigation, he said, therefore New Delhi should treat the matter as very urgent. Kaarthikeyan's pressure worked.

A breakthrough happened in the first week of June, when a naval vessel intercepted a communication to Jaffna from somewhere in Tamil Nadu. The problem was in cracking the code. Neither Ragothaman nor anyone in the SIT was equipped to crack alphanumeric codes. Verma had an idea—Arivu Peraribalan, who had innovated the vest bomb to kill Rajiv Gandhi and was already in their custody. He got Peraribalan to decode the intercepts. At first, Peraribalan feigned ignorance but finally decoded the messages and showed how Sivarasan had modified the use of alphanumeric codes to maintain greater secrecy. Sivarasan's message was an urgent request for a boat to ferry him across the Palk Strait.

But Jaffna was not responding to such messages positively. It baffled Verma. He took up the matter internally. Was the LTTE supremo Prabhakaran trying to dump Sivarasan? Why, then, would he not help his most prized soldier out? The assassin's utility might have been over for Prabhakaran but Sivarasan being in police custody could not have been good news for the LTTE boss either. However, it confirmed one thing—Sivarasan was still in India.

The next day they intercepted another message that indicated that Sivarasan could be somewhere near Anna Nagar in Madras. The tracking team led by Raju and Kanth, along with NSG commandos, raided the suspected hideout. But there was no sign of the fugitive. He seemed to have used that hideout only to send out messages and never lived there.

Based on another tip-off, the tracking team, consisting of Verma, Ragothaman and Ravindran, and his Black Cat commandos in plain clothes,